Yadav, relocated some 20,000 policemen to protect the Babri Masjid. 72 Infantry Brigade of which we were part, was placed on standby for internal security (IS) duties. A possible task for us was to hold the bridge over the Saryu River and to stop anyone from crossing it. We had returned from Sri Lanka only about six months earlier and still had quick trigger fingers. The orders for us, therefore, were that charged magazines would not be loaded on the rifles but kept in the magazine pouch, to be taken out only on orders. Fortunately, good sense prevailed and we were not called out but only kept on standby. Even today, I shudder to think of what might have been our response when faced with thousands of kar sevaks. Would we have fired on our own countrymen? Unarmed countrymen at that? It brought home the point very forcefully that the Army should not be called in to deal with law-and-order situations. That is the primary responsibility of the state's police force and, if beyond their capability, of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) like the CRPF. As it so happened, on the designated day, about 40,000 kar sevaks reached the bridge leading to Ayodhya and several of them climbed the masjid in an attempt to tear it down. However, under the Chief Minister's order, the police fired at them and a scuffle broke out, killing several kar sevaks and the attempt was abandoned. We kept listening to the news with bated breath and were positively relieved when the orders came to stand down.

A year in Gwalior is all I got, as in April it was time to pack again for the move to Wellington. It was the same sequence of packing, fixing up a truck, getting the luggage loaded, handing over the house and then boarding a train to the next destination. In close to seven years of married life, Veena had already been to six different places—Budhwal, Binaguri, Fatehgarh, Pune (SF) and Gwalior, as well as a three-month sojourn at Mhow

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